

Say It Ain't So

Baseball's Gambling Problem Before the Black Sox

15 MINUTE HISTORY · NARRATION SCRIPT · 1,709 WORDS · ABOUT 9:34

Driving question: *How did betting go from part of the game, to baseball's unforgivable sin, and back again?*

Underlined = vocabulary card on screen · *italic* = spoken with emphasis · timestamps are estimates until the voice is recorded

0:00 Two Documents

August 3rd, 1921. A one-paragraph statement from baseball's brand-new boss, Judge Kenesaw Mountain Landis.

"Regardless of the verdict of juries," it says, "no player that throws a ball game... will ever play professional baseball."

Eight Chicago White Sox players are out. For life. The day before, a jury had found them *not guilty*.

Now jump ahead 105 years. March 2026. Another one-page document. Major League Baseball names an official partner: Polymarket, a **prediction market**, where people trade on what's going to happen. Including baseball games.

Same sport. One document bans players over gambling. The other names a prediction market an official partner.

So it's easy to think that back then gambling was taboo, and now it's everywhere. But that's not quite how it went. Before 1919, gambling in baseball wasn't taboo. It was *everywhere*.

So here's the question I want to answer today: How did betting go from part of the game, to baseball's unforgivable sin, and back again?

It starts with a catcher who couldn't catch.

1:04 **Everybody Bet**

Baseball and betting grew up together.

In the 1860s, baseball is America's hot new game, and crowds bet on it the same way they bet on horse races. Gamblers run something called **pool selling**: they auction off shares in a betting pool on a game, often right there at the ballpark.

And if people are betting on games, someone is going to try to rig one.

September 28th, 1865. Hoboken, New Jersey. The New York Mutuals, one of the best teams around, play the Brooklyn Eckfords. The Mutuals' catcher, William Wansley, has a terrible day. Six passed balls. The Eckfords score 11 runs in one inning and win, 23 to 11.

Bad day? Not exactly. A gambler had reportedly paid Wansley 100 dollars to lose. Wansley brought in two teammates and gave them a cut. That's called **throwing a game**: losing on purpose, for money. It's the first fixed game in baseball we can document.

All three players were banned. Within five years, all three were back.

Remember that. It's going to keep happening.

2:02 **On Paper**

By the 1870s, fans had a word for fixed games: "hippodroming," like a staged race at the circus. Plenty of fans assumed any loss might be bought.

So in 1876, a Chicago businessman named William Hulbert starts a new league, the National League, and promises to clean the game up. No betting pools at the ballpark. No beer. Players who throw games are gone.

The promise gets tested in year two. 1877. The Louisville Grays are cruising toward the pennant. Then, in August, they collapse. Errors. Wild

throws. Loss after loss.

A local newspaperman starts asking questions. The club's vice president notices his players getting a lot of telegrams. So he demands to read them.

The telegrams show that pitcher Jim Devlin, outfielder George Hall and utility man Al Nichols had taken gamblers' money to lose. A fourth player, the team captain, Bill Craver, refused to hand his over.

The league banned all four. For life. And unlike 1865, it meant it. Devlin begged to be let back in, year after year. Hulbert said no every time.

So the rule against gambling isn't new. It's been there almost from the start. *On paper.*

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Quick thing before we go on. If you're enjoying this, hit subscribe. It's free, it really helps the channel, and unlike William Wansley, nobody's paying me to say it.

3:15 The Open Secret

But a rule is only as strong as the people enforcing it. And for the next 40 years, almost nobody wanted to look.

Baseball booms. By the 1900s there are two major leagues, big new ballparks and a World Series. The betting comes right along with it. Bettors work openly in the stands. Players bet. Club officials bet. Usually on their own team to win. Not always.

Why didn't anyone stop it? Because enforcing the rule meant admitting there was a problem. A fixed game is bad for business. So is telling your customers about one. Clubs usually handled suspicious players *quietly*. A trade. A release. No headlines.

Umpires weren't off limits either. In 1882, an umpire named Dick Higham was caught writing letters to a gambler, tipping him off on which way to

bet. He's still the only umpire ever banned for life.

And in October 1908, the Giants and the Cubs play one game to decide the pennant. Before it, a man offers umpire Bill Klem thousands of dollars to make the close calls go New York's way. Klem says no, and reports it.

The man turns out to be the Giants' own team doctor. He's banned from every ballpark for life. Who sent him? Nobody really asks.

Which seems like the obvious next question.

4:27 Prince Hal

And then there's Hal Chase.

Chase might be the best-fielding first baseman of his time. Fans call him Prince Hal. He's also, according to several of his own managers, losing games on purpose.

1910. His manager in New York accuses him of it. The team's owner sides with Chase. The manager is the one who leaves. Chase gets his job.

1918. Chase is playing for Cincinnati. His manager, the great pitcher Christy Mathewson, suspends him for offering bribes to teammates and opponents.

The case goes to the National League president in January 1919. Mathewson can't testify. He's in France, serving in World War One. Key witnesses don't show. The president rules there isn't enough evidence. Chase is cleared.

A few weeks later, the New York Giants sign him.

So think about what every player in baseball just learned. You can be accused by your own manager. Twice. And still have a job.

That's baseball in 1919. Now, about the White Sox.

5:21 The Fix

The 1919 Chicago White Sox might be the best team in baseball. Shoeless Joe Jackson, one of the best hitters alive. Eddie Cicotte, 29 wins. They're heavy favorites in the World Series against the Cincinnati Reds.

You've probably heard why some of them turned. Their owner, Charles Comiskey, was so cheap he underpaid everyone, and even benched his star pitcher to dodge a bonus. Some of that is legend. Salary records show the White Sox had one of the highest payrolls in baseball, and there's no evidence for the bonus story. But some players *felt* cheated, and they were angry.

First baseman Chick Gandil goes to the gamblers. The plan: lose the Series for 100,000 dollars. Eight players are in on it, or at least know about it. The money reportedly traces back to New York's biggest gambler, Arnold Rothstein.

October 1st, 1919. Game 1. Cicotte's second pitch hits the Reds' leadoff man square in the back. That's the signal. The fix is on.

Not exactly subtle.

Right before the Series, the betting odds had swung hard toward Cincinnati. Sportswriters noticed. A few said so out loud. The Reds win the best-of-nine Series, 5 games to 3.

And Joe Jackson? He hits .375 and makes no errors. People have argued about what that means for a hundred years.

By their own accounts, the players got only part of the money they were promised.

6:38 Regardless of the Verdict

For almost a year, it's a rumor. Then, in September 1920, a grand jury in Chicago, a panel that decides if there's enough evidence for a trial, starts

looking into gambling in baseball. Cicotte breaks down and confesses. So does Jackson. He says he took 5,000 dollars.

Outside the courthouse, the story goes, a little boy looks up at Jackson and begs, "Say it ain't so, Joe." It's a great line. Jackson said it never happened.

The owners are scared. A fixed World Series can't be handled quietly. So they hire a federal judge, Kenesaw Mountain Landis, as baseball's first **commissioner**, with almost total power over the game.

Summer 1921. The trial. The players take back their confessions. On August 2nd, the jury finds them all *not guilty*. Some jurors reportedly celebrate with the players afterward.

The next day, Landis bans all eight anyway. For life.

Even third baseman Buck Weaver, who took no money and played hard. He knew about the fix and didn't report it. That was enough.

This time, nobody came back. That's the wall. Gambling goes from an open secret to the one thing baseball *will not forgive*.

7:42 Full Circle

Baseball later wrote it down in plain words, Rule 21, and posted it in every clubhouse. Bet on a game you have a part in, and you're banned for life.

The wall held for most of a century. In 1989, Pete Rose, baseball's all-time hits leader, was banned for betting on games while managing the Cincinnati Reds.

Then the law changed. In 2018, the Supreme Court cleared the way for states to legalize sports betting. Within a few years, betting apps were sponsoring teams and advertising during games.

In 2025, baseball ruled that a lifetime ban ends at death. That took Joe Jackson, the rest of the 1919 Sox, and Pete Rose off the banned list.

That same year, federal prosecutors charged two Cleveland pitchers with rigging single pitches for bettors placing microbets, bets on a single pitch. Both pleaded not guilty, and when this video was made, their case hadn't gone to trial.

In 2026, baseball signed its deal with Polymarket. Part of that deal keeps markets on single pitches off the board.

So let's go back to the question. How did betting go from part of the game, to the unforgivable sin, and back?

It was never really gone. Before 1919, the rule existed, but enforcing it meant admitting a problem, so mostly nobody did. 1919 was too big to hide. So baseball built a wall and kept it up for a hundred years.

Now the line has moved. Fans can bet. Leagues can partner with sportsbooks and prediction markets. The rule that stays is the one from 1921: the people on the field can't be in on it.

To supporters, that's betting out in the open, regulated and watched for anything suspicious. To critics, it puts a bet in every fan's pocket, and more temptation close to the game.

Either way, since Hoboken in 1865, the question has never been *whether* people will bet on baseball.

It's who's watching when they do.

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